Grassroots Conversations

IF YOU HEAR THIS

“I’m done / sitting this one out.”

This page is for when someone is frustrated and ready to sit the election out. Listen first. Talk from the heart. Don’t argue. Find the one local issue that would make it worth showing up for their family.

Short Bridge

Use this after you’ve listened and let them know you heard them. It’s one or two sentences that move the talk from the national noise to something local they care about, and it ends with a question so they keep talking. If they open up, keep listening. If not, thank them and move on.

“A lot of people feel that way. What’s the one local result that would make it worth showing up for your family?”

The Issue and Expanded Bridge

The facts behind the issue and a longer bridge, for when they want to keep talking.

The issue

Burnout is common after years of high-volume national politics. People sit out because they feel their vote or voice does not change anything.

Short background

Locally the opposite is often true. Low turnout in precincts, school-board races, city councils, or bond elections means relatively small numbers of organized voters decide outcomes that affect taxes, safety, water, and services. When good people sit out, the decisions are still made — just by whoever shows up.

The bridge

“I get the frustration — a lot of people feel done. The catch is that when good people sit out, the decisions still get made by whoever shows up. On the issue that’s weighing on you most right now, would you be open to one small step — checking your registration or talking with the next neighbor?” Listen, mirror, and close on that single commitment.

Ownership close: “We are the they. What’s the one thing you’ll own this month?”

Deeper Background

For your own preparation. You don't need to recite this. It helps you understand why people feel this way and answer questions with confidence.

Why people sit out

Repeated national cycles create fatigue. Many voters conclude that individual participation is futile because the issues that dominate media are distant from daily life. The emotional logic is understandable; the practical consequence is that local races with lower visibility are decided by smaller, more organized groups.

Supporting local context

- In many Yavapai County precincts and local contests, turnout is significantly lower than in presidential races. Small shifts in participation can change results on school boards, bonds, and municipal races that directly affect taxes, services, and growth management.
- Residents consistently name costs, housing, water with growth, and neighborhood safety as the issues that matter most. These are decided locally more than nationally.

The perspective shift

Sitting out does not stop decisions; it transfers them to whoever remains organized. The useful reframe is not "you must care about politics." It is "the issue you already care about will still be decided — and one small action changes who decides it." This restores a sense of agency without demanding high-volume engagement.

Ownership close

"We are the they. Who's the next neighbor, the next person, you'll talk to?"

2-Minute Two-Person Conversation

A sample conversation from start to finish. Practice it with a partner until it sounds like you.

Setting: Front porch or sidewalk. Neighbor has just said they're done and sitting this one out.

Neighbor: Honestly, I'm done. I'm sitting this one out. Nothing I do changes anything.
You: I hear you. After years of the national noise, a lot of people feel exactly that way.
Neighbor: It's the same fight over and over.
You: It is. A lot of people feel that way. What's the one local result that would make it worth showing up for your family?
Neighbor: I guess the cost of everything. And the roads, with all the new building.
You: Those get decided right here — city council, the county, the school board. When good people sit out, those decisions still get made, just by whoever shows up. Local races don't draw many voters, so a few neighbors can make a real difference.

Neighbor: I hadn’t really thought of it that way.
You: I’m not asking you to jump into the national fight. Would you be open to one small step — checking your registration, or talking with one neighbor about the roads?
Neighbor: I could check my registration.
You: That’s great. I’ll follow up next week. We are the they.

Neighbors talking to neighbors. We are the they.